Class 7 Social Science – Chapter 8

How the Land Becomes Sacred

NCERT: Exploring Society – India and Beyond, Grade 7, Part 1 | Reprint 2026–27

यहाँ आपकी PDF के आधार पर अध्याय के सभी मुख्य विषयों के प्रश्न-उत्तर और पुस्तक के अंत में दिए गए सभी 8 अभ्यास प्रश्नों के उत्तर simple English में दिए गए हैं। साथ ही, Let's Explore और Think About It गतिविधियों के नमूना उत्तर भी शामिल हैं। उत्तर कक्षा 7 के स्तर के अनुसार रखे गए हैं।

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1. Important topics of the chapter

1. Meaning of Sacredness
2. Sacred Places, Shrines and Pilgrimages
3. Sacred Places in Different Religions
4. Tirtha and Tirthayatra
5. Sacred Sites in Nature
6. Sacred Geography of India
7. Char Dham, Jyotirlingas and Shakti Pithas
8. Cultural Integration through Pilgrimage
9. Sacred Ecology
10. Rivers and Sangams
11. Kumbh Mela
12. Sacred Mountains and Forests
13. Trees and Sacred Groves
14. Pilgrimage and Trade
15. Sacred Geography beyond India
16. Restoration and Conservation of Sacred Places

2. Meaning of Sacredness

Q1. What is sacredness?

Answer: Sacredness means being holy or having deep religious or spiritual importance. A place, object, journey or part of nature may be considered sacred.

Q2. What is a sacred place?

Answer: A sacred place is a place that people respect because of its religious or spiritual importance.

Q3. What is a shrine?

Answer: A shrine is a place regarded as holy because it is connected with a deity, sacred relic or spiritual figure.

Q4. What is a pilgrimage?

Answer: A pilgrimage is a journey to a sacred place that is important in a religion or belief system.

Q5. Is sacredness connected only with religion?

Answer: No. Sacredness is connected with religion, spirituality, geography, nature and cultural traditions.

Q6. Why do people respect sacred places?

Answer: People respect sacred places because they are connected with their beliefs, traditions, religious figures or important events.

3. Sacred Places in Different Religions

Q1. Which sacred places are important in Buddhism?

Answer: Sanchi is important because it has the Great Stupa, which contains sacred relics. Bodh Gaya is important because, according to Buddhist tradition, the Buddha attained enlightenment there.

Q2. What is a relic?

Answer: A relic is a part of a saint's or spiritual figure's body, or an object that belonged to that person and is kept with respect.

Q3. What is a Takht in Sikhism?

Answer: A Takht is a seat or centre of spiritual authority in Sikhism.

Q4. Name three important Sikh Takhts mentioned in the chapter.

Answer: Takht Sri Patna Sahib, Akal Takht at Amritsar and Takht Sri Keshgarh Sahib at Anandpur.

Q5. Why do Sikhs visit these Takhts?

Answer: They visit them because these places are associated with important Sikh Gurus and have special religious significance.

Q6. Name two sacred places connected with religions that originated outside India.

Answer: The Dargah Sharif of Ajmer and the Velankanni Church in Tamil Nadu.

Q7. What are the Jain tirthas associated with?

Answer: They are associated with places where the Tirthankaras attained liberation or where important events of their lives took place.

Q8. Name three sacred Jain places mentioned in the chapter.

Answer: Mount Abu, Girnar and Shatrunjaya Hill in Gujarat.

Q9. Why is Sabarimala important?

Answer: Sabarimala in Kerala is a hilltop shrine dedicated to Ayyappa. Many devotees visit it on pilgrimage.

4. Tirtha and Tirthayatra

Q1. What is a tirtha?

Answer: A tirtha literally means a place where one can cross a river or another body of water. Spiritually, it is a place where a person can move from ordinary life towards a higher spiritual life.

Q2. What is a tirthayatra?

Answer: A tirthayatra is a journey to sacred places. It is both a physical journey and an inner journey of spiritual growth.

Q3. How old is the tradition of pilgrimage in India?

Answer: According to the chapter, Indians have travelled to sacred places for at least 3,000 years.

Q4. Why did people undertake long pilgrimages in ancient times?

Answer: People travelled to worship, visit sacred places, learn from teachers, discuss ideas and meet people from different regions.

Q5. Why were pilgrimages difficult in ancient times?

Answer: People did not have modern transport. They often travelled on foot, carried food and other necessities, and spent many days or months on the journey.

Q6. How can a pilgrimage be an inner journey?

Answer: A pilgrimage can help people reflect on their lives, develop self-discipline and strengthen their spiritual beliefs.

Q7. What does the Pandharpur Wari show?

Answer: It shows the long tradition of group pilgrimage in India. Pilgrims walk together for about 21 days to reach the Vithoba temple at Pandharpur in Maharashtra.

5. Sacred Sites in Nature

Q1. Why are rivers, mountains, trees and forests considered sacred?

Answer: Many people believe that divine power is present in nature. Rivers provide water, forests support life, and mountains are associated with deities and spiritual traditions.

Q2. What is Bhūdevī?

Answer: Bhūdevī means Mother Earth. In Hindu traditions, the Earth is regarded as sacred and is represented as a divine mother.

Q3. What is the importance of Niyam Dongar?

Answer: Niyam Dongar in Odisha is sacred to the Dongria Khond tribe. They believe it is the home of Niyam Raja, who provides what they need to live. Cutting trees there is considered disrespectful.

Q4. How do the Todas regard nature?

Answer: The Todas of the Nilgiris consider many mountain peaks, plants, Shola forests, wetlands, stones and individual trees sacred.

Q5. How did Sikkim protect its sacred natural sites?

Answer: The Government of Sikkim identified sacred mountains, caves, lakes, rocks and hot springs for protection against damage.

Q6. What is the connection between sacredness and nature conservation?

Answer: When people consider a natural place sacred, they may avoid cutting trees, hunting animals or damaging the area. This helps protect nature.

6. Sacred Geography of India

Q1. What is sacred geography?

Answer: Sacred geography is the network of places, rivers, mountains, forests and routes that people consider sacred because of their religious and cultural importance.

Q2. How does the land become sacred?

Answer: The land becomes sacred when people associate it with deities, religious events, holy figures, pilgrimage routes and traditional stories.

Q3. What is the Char Dham Yatra?

Answer: The Char Dham Yatra is a pilgrimage connecting four sacred places located in the northern, southern, eastern and western parts of India.

Q4. What are Jyotirlingas?

Answer: Jyotirlingas are 12 sacred shrines dedicated to Shiva. Each has its own name and religious story.

Q5. What are Shakti Pithas?

Answer: Shakti Pithas are sacred places associated with the divine mother, Shakti. According to the tradition described in the chapter, they mark the places where parts of Sati's body fell.

Q6. How do the Char Dham, Jyotirlingas and Shakti Pithas create sacred geography?

Answer: They connect places across different regions of the Subcontinent. Pilgrims travelling between them experience the land as a connected sacred space.

Q7. How does sacred geography connect people from different parts of India?

Answer: Pilgrims travel across regions, meet people who speak different languages and follow different customs, and discover shared beliefs and traditions. This creates a sense of cultural connection.

Q8. What did Jawaharlal Nehru say about Indian pilgrimages?

Answer: He observed that pilgrimages from the Himalayas to Kanyakumari helped people feel that India was one country with one culture.

7. Cultural Integration through Pilgrimage

Q1. What is cultural integration?

Answer: Cultural integration is the process through which people from different regions share ideas, customs, beliefs and experiences and develop a sense of connection.

Q2. How did pilgrimage routes help cultural integration in India?

Answer: Pilgrims travelled long distances and met people with different languages, foods, clothing and customs. They also discovered similarities in their beliefs and traditions.

Q3. Did people travel only for religious reasons?

Answer: No. Merchants travelled to exchange goods, while scholars and teachers travelled to learn, teach, discuss and spread ideas.

Q4. How did different journeys benefit society?

Answer: People exchanged goods, knowledge, stories and experiences. This helped new ideas develop and old traditions spread to new regions.

Q5. Why is pilgrimage important for national unity?

Answer: Pilgrimage connects distant places and allows people to experience shared traditions. It helps build a feeling of belonging to a larger cultural community.

8. Sacred Ecology

Q1. What is sacred ecology?

Answer: Sacred ecology is the understanding that nature and the environment are sacred and should be treated with respect and care.

Q2. What is a punyakshetra?

Answer: A punyakshetra is a sacred area, often connected with a river, lake, forest or mountain.

Q3. How does sacred ecology help protect nature?

Answer: When people regard a river, forest or mountain as sacred, they may protect it from pollution, cutting, hunting and other harmful activities.

Q4. How are geography, culture and spirituality connected?

Answer: Sacred places are often found in natural settings. Religious beliefs and local traditions give these places meaning, while their natural features support people's lives and activities.

Q5. Why should we protect sacred natural places?

Answer: They are important for religion, culture, biodiversity and the environment. Protecting them also helps preserve them for future generations.

9. Rivers and Sangams

Q1. Why are rivers considered sacred in India?

Answer: Rivers have supported human life and civilisation for thousands of years. Many people also believe that rivers have divine importance.

Q2. What is a sangam?

Answer: A sangam is the confluence, or meeting point, of two or more rivers.

Q3. What is the Nadistuti Sukta?

Answer: It is a hymn in the Rigveda that praises rivers and invokes 19 major rivers of ancient northwestern India.

Q4. Name the rivers mentioned in the prayer in the chapter.

Answer: Ganga, Yamuna, Godavari, Sarasvati, Narmada, Sindhu and Kaveri.

Q5. Why are the sources and tributaries of rivers also considered sacred?

Answer: They are part of the river system and are connected with the river's religious and cultural significance.

Q6. How are rivers important for civilisation?

Answer: Rivers provide water, support farming and settlements, and help people travel and exchange goods. They have also played an important role in religious and cultural life.

10. Kumbh Mela

Q1. What is the Kumbh Mela?

Answer: The Kumbh Mela is a major religious gathering held at sacred river locations in India. Pilgrims gather there during an auspicious period to bathe in the rivers.

Q2. Where is the Kumbh Mela held?

Answer: The four places associated with the Kumbh Mela in the chapter are Haridwar, Prayagraj, Nashik and Ujjain.

Q3. What is the traditional story behind the Kumbh Mela?

Answer: According to the story of the churning of the cosmic ocean, the gods and demons sought amrita, the nectar of immortality. Vishnu, in the form of Mohini, took the pitcher containing the nectar, and drops fell at four places. These places became associated with the Kumbh Mela.

Q4. Why is Prayagraj important?

Answer: Prayagraj is associated with the confluence of the Ganga, Yamuna and the traditionally described invisible Sarasvati. It is an important pilgrimage centre.

Q5. What is the cultural importance of the Kumbh Mela?

Answer: It brings together large numbers of pilgrims from different regions. It supports religious traditions, cultural exchange and local economic activity.

Q6. How is the Kumbh Mela connected with the economy?

Answer: Pilgrims need food, transport, accommodation and other goods and services. This creates work and income for traders, shopkeepers, transport workers and local communities.

11. Sacred Mountains and Forests

Q1. Why are mountains often considered sacred?

Answer: Mountains are often associated with deities, legends and heroes. Their great height is sometimes seen as a symbolic connection between Earth and heaven.

Q2. Why are many temples built on hilltops?

Answer: Reaching a hilltop shrine often requires a difficult journey. This physical effort can symbolise the spiritual effort needed to reach the divine.

Q3. Name four sacred mountain or hill locations shown in the chapter.

Answer: Mount Kailash, Vaishno Devi Temple at Katra, Tiruvannamalai in Tamil Nadu and the Tirumala hills associated with Lord Balaji.

Q4. How have modern transport facilities changed pilgrimage?

Answer: Roads and other forms of transport have made many sacred places easier to reach than in the past, when pilgrims often travelled on foot.

Q5. Why should forests around sacred places be protected?

Answer: These forests may contain many plants and animals, protect water sources and preserve cultural traditions.

12. Trees, Forests and Sacred Groves

Q1. Which tree is known as the peepul, pipal, bo tree or bodhi tree?

Answer: It is the Ficus religiosa, known in Sanskrit as ashvattha.

Q2. Which religions consider the peepul tree sacred?

Answer: Hinduism, Buddhism, Sikhism and Jainism.

Q3. Why is the Bodhi tree at Bodh Gaya important?

Answer: According to Buddhist tradition, the Buddha attained enlightenment under the original tree. The tree at the Mahabodhi Temple is regarded as a descendant of that tree.

Q4. What evidence shows that the peepul tree has been important for a long time?

Answer: A seal from Mohenjo-daro shows peepul leaves. This suggests that the tree was part of the cultural landscape of the region thousands of years ago.

Q5. What are sacred groves?

Answer: Sacred groves are areas of forest protected by communities because they are believed to be the homes of deities or have special religious importance.

Q6. Why are sacred groves important for biodiversity?

Answer: They protect plants, animals and natural habitats from harmful activities such as tree cutting, hunting and mining.

Q7. How do sacred groves help conserve water?

Answer: Many sacred groves contain small water bodies. Protecting the vegetation and land around them can help conserve water.

Q8. Name some regional names for sacred groves given in the chapter.

Answer:

- Malayalam — kāvu
- Tamil — kovilkādu

- Kannada — devare kādu
- Marathi — devarāī
- Khasi — khlaw kyntang
- Hindi (Himachal Pradesh) — dev van
- Jharkhand — sarnā
- Chhattisgarh — devgudi
- Rajasthan — oran

Q9. How do sacred groves help maintain a relationship between people and nature?

Answer: Sacred groves encourage people to protect forests, wildlife and water sources. They connect religious beliefs with the conservation of nature.

Q10. Why are sacred groves disappearing in some regions?

Answer: Some sacred groves are shrinking because land is being used for farming, industries and other activities. This damages natural habitats and cultural heritage.

13. From Pilgrimage to Trade

Q1. How are pilgrimage routes connected with trade routes?

Answer: Pilgrims need food and other supplies during their journeys. Traders travel along the same routes to sell goods, so pilgrimage routes and trade routes often overlap.

Q2. What were the Uttarapatha and Dakshinapatha?

Answer: Uttarapatha was a major trade route connecting the northwestern and eastern parts of the Subcontinent. Dakshinapatha ran from Kaushambi through Ujjayini to Pratishthana.

Q3. What goods were traded along ancient routes?

Answer: Goods included precious stones, shells, pearls, coins, gold, diamonds, cotton, spices and sandalwood.

Q4. How did pilgrimage help local economies?

Answer: Pilgrims bought food, clothing, offerings and other goods. They also needed transport and accommodation. This created income for local traders and service providers.

Q5. Could traders also be pilgrims?

Answer: Yes. Some traders carried goods to distant towns and cities while visiting sacred sites along the way.

Q6. How did pilgrimage and trade together help cultural exchange?

Answer: Both brought people from different regions together. They exchanged goods, languages, ideas, stories and customs.

14. Sacred Geography beyond India

Q1. Is sacred geography unique to India?

Answer: No. Other parts of the world also have sacred mountains, forests and natural places.

Q2. How did ancient Greeks view nature?

Answer: Ancient Greeks regarded many natural landmarks, including mountains and sacred groves, as important in their religious traditions.

Q3. How did Native Americans view nature?

Answer: Many Native American communities had a special relationship with nature and viewed it as sacred.

Q4. Why is Taranaki Maunga sacred to the Maoris?

Answer: The Maoris, the Indigenous people of New Zealand, regard Taranaki Maunga as their ancestor and consider it sacred.

Q5. What does the example of Taranaki Maunga teach us?

Answer: It shows that communities may protect natural places because of their spiritual and cultural relationships with them. Such beliefs can influence environmental protection.

15. Restoring and Conserving Sacred Places

Q1. Why are some sacred rivers polluted today?

Answer: Rivers may become polluted because of untreated sewage, waste disposal, industrial pollution and careless human activities.

Q2. Who is responsible for protecting sacred places?

Answer: Governments, local communities, religious organisations, visitors and every citizen share responsibility for protecting sacred places.

Q3. How can we protect sacred rivers and forests?

Answer: We can avoid throwing waste into rivers, reduce plastic use, plant trees, prevent illegal cutting, protect wildlife and support proper waste management.

Q4. Why is conservation of sacred places important?

Answer: It protects cultural heritage, biodiversity, water resources and the natural environment for future generations.

Q5. What does the chapter mean by a harmonious relationship between people and sacred geography?

Answer: It means that people respect and protect the natural places they consider sacred. This relationship can support cultural values and environmental conservation.

Q6. How can sacred geography contribute to sustainability today?

Answer: It encourages people to see rivers, mountains, forests and animals as valuable parts of life, not merely as resources to use. This attitude can encourage responsible and sustainable behaviour.

16. Textbook questions and activities — answers in simple English

The following answers correspond to the eight questions on pages 183–184 of your PDF.

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Question 1. What does David Suzuki's statement mean? What does it imply for our actions towards air, water, land, trees and mountains?

Answer:

David Suzuki's statement means that the way we think about nature affects how we treat it. If we regard a mountain as sacred, we will respect it instead of destroying it for minerals. If we consider a river a living part of the land, we will protect it instead of polluting it. If we see a forest as a sacred home for plants and animals, we will avoid cutting trees unnecessarily.

This idea teaches us to respect nature and understand that humans are part of the natural world. We should keep the air and water clean, protect forests, conserve soil and prevent damage to mountains. We should use natural resources carefully and think about future generations.

Question 2. List sacred sites in your region. Why are they sacred? Write a short essay of about 150 words.

Sample answer: Sacred Places in and around Siwan, Bihar

My region, Siwan in Bihar, has several places of religious and cultural importance. People visit local temples, mosques, shrines and other places of worship to pray and take part in religious activities. These places are important because they are connected with faith, local traditions and community life.

In Bihar, Bodh Gaya is one of the most important sacred places for Buddhists. According to Buddhist tradition, Gautama Buddha attained enlightenment there. Patna Sahib is a major Sikh pilgrimage centre associated with Guru Gobind Singh. People from different parts of India visit these places to pray and learn about their religious traditions.

Sacred places also bring people together during festivals and special occasions. They support local shops, transport and other services. We should keep these places clean and protect their surroundings. Sacred places are not only important for religion; they are also part of our cultural heritage.

Note: This is a sample essay. You can replace the examples with sacred places you know in your own locality.

Question 3. Why are rivers, mountains and forests considered sacred? How do they contribute to our lives?

Answer:

Rivers, mountains and forests are considered sacred because many people believe they have divine or spiritual importance. Religious stories and traditions connect them with gods, saints and important events.

These natural features are also essential for human life. Rivers provide water for drinking, farming and other activities. Mountains influence climate and provide water through streams and rivers. Forests provide oxygen, shelter for wildlife, food, medicines and other resources.

When people regard these places as sacred, they may protect them from pollution and destruction. Respecting nature can therefore help conserve the environment and preserve cultural traditions.

Question 4. Why do people visit a tirtha or other sacred sites?

Answer:

People visit sacred sites to pray, worship and express their faith. They may wish to remember a religious figure, visit a holy place or take part in a religious festival. Pilgrimage can also be an inner journey that helps people develop self-discipline and spiritual understanding.

People also travel to sacred sites to learn about traditions, meet others who share their beliefs and experience the culture of different regions.

Question 5. How did ancient pilgrimage routes help trade? Do sacred sites help develop the local economy?

Answer:

Ancient pilgrimage routes helped trade because pilgrims needed food, clothing, offerings and other supplies during their journeys. Traders travelled along the same routes to sell goods. Some traders also visited sacred places while carrying their goods to distant towns and cities.

Yes, sacred sites can help develop the local economy. Pilgrims spend money on transport, food, accommodation and religious items. Local shops, guides, hotels, transport workers and craftspeople can earn income from these activities. However, these places must be managed carefully to prevent pollution and damage to the environment.

Question 6. How do sacred places influence the culture and traditions of people living nearby?

Answer:

Sacred places influence local culture through festivals, rituals, stories, songs and traditional practices. People may organise fairs and processions on special occasions. Local craftspeople may make religious objects, and families may pass stories about sacred places from one generation to the next.

These traditions create a sense of belonging and preserve cultural heritage. Sacred places can also attract visitors from other regions, encouraging the exchange of ideas and customs.

Question 7. Choose two sacred sites in India and explain their significance.

Answer: Two Important Sacred Sites in India



1. Bodh Gaya, Bihar

Bodh Gaya is one of the most important sacred places for Buddhists. According to Buddhist tradition, Gautama Buddha attained enlightenment under the Bodhi tree. The Mahabodhi Temple and the Bodhi tree attract pilgrims from India and many other countries. The site is important for Buddhist prayer, meditation and learning.



2. Golden Temple, Amritsar

The Golden Temple, also called Harmandir Sahib, is a major Sikh sacred place in Punjab. It is an important centre of Sikh worship and community service. Its langar provides free meals to visitors. It represents devotion, equality, service and hospitality.

Question 8. What are the two-fold benefits of a tirthayatra or pilgrimage?

Answer:

A tirthayatra has two important benefits.

1. Spiritual benefit: It allows people to worship, strengthen their faith, reflect on their lives and develop spiritually.
2. Social and cultural benefit: It connects people from different regions, encourages the sharing of traditions and ideas, and supports trade and local economic activities.

Thus, pilgrimage benefits both the individual and society.

17. Answers to “Let’s Explore” and “Think About It”

These are classroom activities from different pages of the chapter. Some require local observation or map work, so the answers below are model answers.

Activity 1 — Page 168: Identify familiar sacred places

Question: Do any of the pictures look familiar? Can you name similar places in your neighbourhood?

Answer: Yes. The pictures show places of worship and pilgrimage. Similar places in my neighbourhood may include temples, mosques, churches, gurudwaras and local shrines. People visit them for prayer, worship and community gatherings.

Activity 2 — Page 170: Rameswaram to Haridwar

Question: What do you observe about the group of pilgrims? What route might they have taken, and why did they go straight to Haridwar instead of stopping in Delhi?

Answer: The group travelled for a long time and carried food and other necessities. They had already visited Rameswaram and wanted to continue their pilgrimage to Haridwar. They

probably travelled north through major transport connections. They did not stop in Delhi because they wanted to save time and reach Haridwar before returning home.

Activity 3 — Page 170: Travel from Madurai to Varanasi in ancient times

Question: Which languages would people encounter? How would they communicate? Where would they stay, and what would they eat?

Answer: Travellers from Madurai to Varanasi would encounter Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Marathi, Hindi and other regional languages. They could communicate using familiar words, gestures, interpreters or the help of other travellers. They might stay in rest houses, temples, monasteries or villages. They would eat locally available food, such as rice, grains, pulses, vegetables and fruits.

Activity 4 — Page 173: Char Dham Yatra

Question: What did travelling north–south and east–west imply for people?

Answer: It allowed people to visit sacred places in different regions of India. During these journeys, they encountered different languages, foods and customs. They also discovered shared traditions, helping them develop a feeling of cultural unity.

Activity 5 — Page 174: Identify tirthas on the map

Question: Can you identify some traditional tirthas shown on the map?

Answer: Examples of well-known sacred places and pilgrimage centres shown or discussed in the chapter include Badrinath, Kedarnath, Varanasi, Prayagraj, Bodh Gaya, Sanchi, Rameswaram, Kanchipuram and other important regional tirthas. The map on page 174 shows how these sites are connected across the Subcontinent.

Activity 6 — Page 176: Kumbh Mela population calculation

Question: If an estimated 660 million people participated in the 2025 Kumbh Mela, what proportion of India's population was this?

Answer: The exact proportion depends on the population estimate used. If we use an approximate population of 1.4 billion:

$$\frac{660\text{ million}}{1400\text{ million}}\times100 \approx 47.1\%$$

So, it was approximately 47% of that estimated population. This is a mathematical comparison, not a claim that the number of unique participants equalled that percentage of India's population.

Activity 7 — Page 177: Sacred places and economic life

Question: How are sacred places connected with people's economic activities?

Answer: Sacred places attract pilgrims and visitors. People buy food, flowers, religious objects and other goods. They also need transport and accommodation. This creates work for traders, shopkeepers, transport workers, guides and local craftspeople.

Activity 8 — Page 179: Uses and importance of the peepul tree

Question: Why is the peepul tree important for nature and people?

Answer: The peepul tree is sacred in several Indian religious traditions. According to the chapter, its leaves have been used for some skin ailments and its bark for stomach ailments. The tree also provides food and shelter for birds and other animals. Protecting such trees can support biodiversity and cultural traditions.

Activity 9 — Page 181: Compare pilgrimage routes and trade routes

Question: What would you observe if you placed a map of ancient trade routes over a map of important tirthas?

Answer: Some pilgrimage routes and trade routes would overlap or pass through nearby places. This happened because both pilgrims and traders travelled between important towns and regions. Pilgrims needed supplies, while traders could sell goods to travellers. The routes helped exchange goods, ideas and cultural practices.

Activity 10 — Page 182: Pollution of sacred places

Question: Why are sacred rivers polluted? Who is responsible for protecting them?

Answer: Sacred rivers can become polluted because of sewage, plastic waste, industrial discharge and careless disposal of rubbish. Religious importance alone cannot keep a river clean. Governments must provide proper waste management, industries must control pollution, and citizens and visitors must avoid dumping waste. Religious organisations and local communities can also help by organising clean-up activities and spreading awareness.

18. Extra exam questions from every topic

One-mark questions

Question	Answer
1. What is a pilgrimage?	A journey to a sacred place.
2. What is a shrine?	A place regarded as holy.
3. What is a relic?	A sacred object or part of a spiritual figure's body.
4. What is a sangam?	The meeting point of rivers.
5. What is a sacred grove?	A forest protected because of its sacred importance.
6. What is Bhūdevī?	Mother Earth.
7. What is a tirtha?	A sacred place associated with spiritual crossing or progress.
8. What is a Takht in Sikhism?	A seat of spiritual authority.
9. Which tree is called Ficus religiosa?	The peepul or bodhi tree.
10. Name the four places associated with the Kumbh Mela in the chapter.	Haridwar, Prayagraj, Nashik and Ujjain.
11. What is sacred ecology?	Respecting and protecting nature as sacred.
12. What is cultural integration?	The sharing of traditions and ideas among different communities.

Short-answer questions

Q1. Explain three ways in which pilgrimage connects people.

Answer: Pilgrimage connects people through shared religious beliefs, journeys across different regions and the exchange of customs, stories and ideas.

Q2. How can sacred places help the environment?

Answer: Sacred beliefs may encourage people to protect forests, trees, rivers and wildlife. Sacred groves can preserve biodiversity and help conserve water.

Q3. Why are rivers important both spiritually and economically?

Answer: Rivers are worshipped in many traditions. They also provide water for farming, drinking and settlements and support transport and economic activities.

Q4. How did ancient routes help both pilgrims and merchants?

Answer: Pilgrims used routes to reach sacred places, while merchants used them to carry goods. Both groups met along the way, helping trade and cultural exchange.

Q5. Why should sacred places be protected even if people do not follow the religion associated with them?

Answer: Sacred places are part of cultural heritage and may also protect important natural environments. Respecting them helps preserve history, biodiversity and the traditions of different communities.

Long-answer questions

Q1. Explain how sacred geography helped cultural integration in India.

Answer: Sacred geography connected important religious sites across the Subcontinent. Pilgrims travelled from one region to another to visit sacred rivers, mountains, temples and other places. During their journeys, they encountered different languages, foods, clothing and customs. They also found shared beliefs and traditions. Merchants, teachers and scholars travelled along many of the same routes, exchanging goods and ideas. These interactions helped traditions spread across regions and encouraged a sense of cultural connection. Thus, sacred geography played an important role in cultural integration in India.

Q2. Explain the relationship between sacred places, trade and the local economy.

Answer: Sacred places attract pilgrims and visitors. These people need transport, food, accommodation and religious items. Local shopkeepers, traders, craftspeople and transport workers earn income by providing these goods and services. In ancient India, pilgrimage routes often overlapped with trade routes, allowing merchants to carry goods between distant regions. Pilgrimage and trade therefore supported each other. However, the growth of tourism and pilgrimage must be managed carefully to prevent pollution and protect the sacred environment.

Q3. What are sacred groves? Explain their importance.

Answer: Sacred groves are forest areas protected by communities because they are associated with deities or religious traditions. People may avoid cutting trees, hunting animals or mining in these areas. As a result, sacred groves can provide safe habitats for plants and animals. They may also protect small water bodies and help conserve water. Sacred groves preserve local stories, beliefs and customs. They show how cultural traditions can support the protection of nature.

Q4. Why is it important to restore and conserve sacred places today?

Answer: Many sacred places face pollution, waste disposal, tree cutting and damage caused by human activities. Protecting them is important because they preserve religious traditions, history and cultural heritage. Natural sacred places also support biodiversity and water conservation. Governments, communities, religious organisations and visitors should work together to keep these places clean. Proper waste management, pollution control, tree protection and public awareness can help conserve sacred places for future generations.

19. Quick revision chart

Topic	Key point to remember

Sacredness	Something holy or spiritually important
Pilgrimage	A journey to a sacred place
Tirtha	A sacred place linked with spiritual progress
Sacred geography	Connected network of sacred places and routes
Char Dham	Four sacred pilgrimage centres across different regions
Jyotirlingas	Twelve sacred shrines dedicated to Shiva
Shakti Pithas	Sacred sites associated with the divine mother
Sangam	Confluence of rivers
Kumbh Mela	Major religious gathering at four traditional locations
Sacred ecology	Respecting nature as sacred
Peepul tree	Ficus religiosa, sacred in several Indian traditions
Sacred groves	Forests protected because of sacred beliefs
Uttarapatha	Ancient trade route linking northwestern and eastern regions
Dakshinapatha	Route from Kaushambi through Ujjayini to Pratishthana
Cultural integration	Exchange of ideas, beliefs and customs
Conservation	Protecting sacred places and the environment

Preparation tip: For exams, learn the definitions first, then practise the eight textbook questions. For long answers, include examples from the chapter—such as Bodh Gaya, the Char Dham, the Kumbh Mela, the peepul tree and sacred groves.